

Though a non-profit entity, Raju and his brothers have contributed Rs 86 crore (about 5 per cent) to equip 500 ambulances, pay senior management, conduct research, bring about technology innovations and provide training.

For the 108 team, every call responded to offers a unique learning experience. When Kshtrapal Rajput and Amit Dubey, residents of Nandol village in Gujarat, were injured in a group clash, the enraged combatants did not allow the ambulance team to give them first aid. Instead, they questioned paramedic Hiren Rathod and driver Jagdish Patel about who had called for help.

Convincing them and getting access to the injured took more than 15 minutes, but the seriously injured men were moved to hospital. A week after their recovery, villagers commended the ambulance team, even giving them gifts.

Impressed by the EMRI idea, which he calls "the first window to emergency healthcare", Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy has committed his Government to providing assistance on regulatory issues, funds, leveraging infrastructure and promoting public awareness. The states that have embraced the EMRI model incur 95 per cent of the total

operating expenses towards providing land and buildings and buying ambulances. The service has become a state-wide emergency management system with 652 ambulances taking victims to 3,300 registered hospitals in all 23 districts of the state. EMRI has also introduced 15 specially equipped motorcycles, called Prime Responders In Case of Emergencies (PRICE) in Hyderabad, Visakhapatnam and Vijayawada as these can reach a victim quickly.

Headquartered in Hyderabad, EMRI seems set to grow as a unified emergency service in a few years. Gujarat launched EMRI on August 29, 2007 and

Photographs by A PRABHAKAR RAO

Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

